

UNISON HEALTHCARE - BRANCH UPDATE

From: Christina McAnea, UNISON National Secretary - Health

BRIEFING HC-72-14

3 September 2014

NHS Pay 2015-16 (England)

Who needs to know?

- Health Branches in England (for action)
- Health Branches in Cymru/Wales; N Ireland and Scotland (for information)

Summary:

Government prevents Pay Review Body from recommending a pay rise for 2015-16 in another restricted remit which also heralds further changes to unsocial hours' pay for next year.

In full:

Attached is a copy of the letter sent last week to the Pay Review Body (PRB) by Dr Dan Poulter, Minister of State, concerning the remit for pay for NHS Staff in England.

In this the Government confirms Secretary of State Jeremy Hunt's intention to restrict pay in the NHS in England at least until March 2016, to 0% for 60% of the workforce and 1% non-consolidated only for those at the top of the pay band. This means that those staff who have been at the top of their pay scale for some time will receive exactly the same rates of pay in 2016 as in 2013.

Key points about the PRB remit for NHS Staff in England:

- Instruction not to make recommendations about
 - pay rates;
 - recruitment, retention and motivation issues;
 - regional and local variations in labour markets.
- A request to make 'observations on the barriers and enablers within the AfC pay system, for delivering health care services every day of the week '.
- Instructions to produce a report on the above by **15 July 2015**.

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As you will see from the letter, the Minister is requesting that the PRB make observations about how 7 day services can be provided without increasing the overall spend, prompting fears from UNISON that this will start a process of further cuts being proposed to your unsocial hours' payments.

The remit drives a further wedge into UK-wide pay, instructing the PRB to apply this remit only to staff in England and leaving the devolved administrations to make their own representations to the Review Body.

UNISON's Health Service Group has highlighted the following concerns:

- This confirms that members can expect the pay freeze to continue past the 2015 General Elections.
- The wording of the request for the PRB to look at out of hours work raises the real prospect of changes to your unsocial hours' payments being sought next year.
- This approach underlines the Government's continued failure to address long-term funding issues for the NHS and prompts fears that future service improvements/changes will be paid for with further cuts to pay.

UNISON believes that the public deserves a quality NHS with staff that are well motivated and fairly rewarded for the vital work they do. This confirmation that the pay freeze will continue next year makes it even more important that members use their vote and vote YES in the current ballot to take action for Fair Pay in the NHS.

Branches are asked to **circulate this information to members and urge them to use their vote and return their ballot paper before 18 September**. Full ballot details are available from:

<http://www.unison.org.uk/at-work/health-care/key-issues/health-pay/ballot>.

Healthcare staff need to speak up for themselves – so we can speak up for patients and the NHS.

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